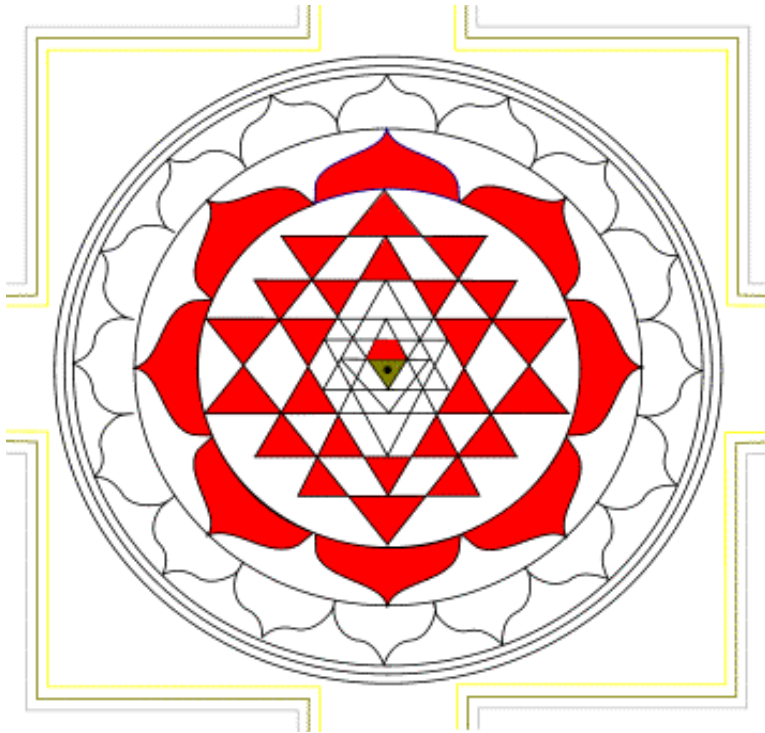




EDITOR IN CHIEF: SWAMI PARANAND TIRTH

YOGTANTRAGAMA
ISSN NO: 2454-888X



April-June 2023



From the Chief Editor's Desk

The tyranny of incalculability and unpredictability.

Transitory-ness and momentary-ness of the essentially ephemeral phenomena is inevitably accompanied by an undercurrent of the streamline of oblivion . We are as it were lured



by the delusive nature to pay a deaf ear and turn a blind eye to the evident and inevitable course of events .

*One moment in annihilation's waste
One moment, of the well of life to taste
The stars are setting, and the caravan
Starts for the dawn of nothing
Oh! make haste (Omar Khayyam)*

Thus reflected Khayyam, a 12th Century Persian polymath and a mystic poet.

The process of annihilation sustenance and creation, says one Shaivite canon occur concomitantly and not successively so presumably Khyyam's moment of annihilation and sustenance signified by drinking from the well of life" and "heading of the caravan into the post apocalyptic phase of creation happen in a single instant of time and also in every instant of time for that matter. Buddha professed impermanence to infuse dispassion . To evade the poignancy of death and depravation , hoary seers suggested two panaceas, dispassion or detachment and adherence to the axiom of an eternal substratum .

One prominent religion of the orient refutes just this . There is no permanent substratum collective or individual one monistic vendantin calls this situation a perpetuated aberrance that has nothing substantial to resort to . All unpredictabilities , incalculabilities and for that matter uncertainties are within the domain of this perpetuated reciprocation of transitory appearance . This axiom correct or fallacious certainly helps us in a pragmatic manner by inculcating dispassion and detachment and thereby counteracting anxieties and fears.

Adherence to the commitment of one's permanent and eternal essential nature requires some intellectual and metaphysical foundation which may be impractical on the nick of the hour . So the tactics of elimination is more consistent than that of the assertion of eternity and infinity of the essential nature . The maxim for a simpleton is different from the one for an adept who is absorbed in the trance of self-consciousness all the time. Albeit as defined in the Gita , a man once seated in his spiritual magnanimity is not agitated by grief no matter how much intense* ,He knows that to be the state of union or Yoga in which identification with the suffering part of the existence -is dissociated *. The main and immediate objective is to pull a man out of the abyss of

miseries and not not helping him climb the summit of supreme bliss. A pessimistic negation of illusory promises is more effective than lofty metaphysical expositions of prenatal and post mortem consequence of a soul along with the omission and commissions of the sequence of karma and their fruition .

Bhartrihari a monarch turned ascetic, muses in his hundred cantos of dispassion

जीवेवारितरंगभंगचपले सौख्यंकुतः प्राणिनाम्।

Owing to this impermanent disposition of existence there isn't an iota of joy for a soul .

*यस्मिन्स्थित्वा न दुखेनगुरूणापिविचात्यते।

SwamiParanand Tirth

Founder president CEO

YTA yoga Tantra &Agama(inc)CAL USA

Centre yoga Tantra et Agama

Montreal Quebec CAN



Editorial



Creation, (Srishti) Sustenance (Stithi) and Dissolution (Samhara) three acts believed to operate in a cyclical manner are popularly seen manifested as holy Trinity Brahma, Vishnu and Shiva. Shaivadvaitavada sees these as functions of Paramashiva along with his Shakti and also adds Veiling (Tirodhana) and Anugraha (Grace) as his function. The illusory nature of time makes one feel that these functions follow each other in a linear fashion. Agamas claim that this notion of linearity is an illusion and actually all the functions happen all the time. The idea is difficult to comprehend hence various metaphorical and allegorical representations are created to explain the lofty concepts to the people.

Here the art of poetic depiction both verbal and visual come handy because what cannot be stated in ordinary language can be very well expressed through the poetic works of art in a synoptic manner. These works have the power to bypass the intellect and directly appeal to the soul and hence have an ability to generate sublime experiences. Whether these are soulful verses of Maulana Rumi giving vent to his extreme longing or the fascinating sculpture of Ardhnarishwara in the Elephanta caves, works of Art have a tremendous capacity to create a strong imaginative world around them provided the receiver is a 'sa-hridaya'.

Explaining the notion we begin with the insightful editorial by our Guru Maharaj, Swami Paranand Tirth ji on the ways in which the truth

can dawn on a true aspirant. "A man once seated in his spiritual magnanimity is not agitated by grief no matter how much intense, He knows that to be the state of union or Yoga in which identification with the suffering part of the existence is dissociated".

Next we have translation and exposition of 5th verse of 'Neel Saraswati Stotram' from 'Brihanneel Tantra'. In this verse the aspirant refuses to seek favours of demigods since they are confined to their meagre relative and transitory godhood which is acquired through Ma Tara's munificence only.

'An analysis of the eternity of the elements of semantic relationship in the context of the Trikaagama text of Śrīmad Abhinavagupta' is the title of the next academic paper by Shivananda Behera where he systematically explores the notion of word, meaning and the relation between them from an esoteric perspective.

Next we have an article by Dr G.L Kaw on "Ishavasya Upanishad. Ishavasya Upanishad is one of the oldest and derives its name from the Opening word of the text—Isha. The core purpose of the text seems to emphasise on the essential unity of the God and the world".

Following this we have a soulful poem eulogizing the divine feminine titled 'Universal Mother' by Rashneek Kher.

Next we have the translation and exposition on two sutras (15th and 16th) of Pratyabhijna Hridayam by Kshemraj from the YTA study circle. The issue ends with two heartfelt poems by Prof. Ambika Talwar titled 'Notes of Resolution' and 'Gratitude Stirs'.



(Kimiya)

NEEL SARASWATI STOTRAM

(A Hymn to the sapphire goddess of wisdom from Brihanneel Tantra) Cont.



Semiotic depictions of metaphysical phenomena .

त्वत्पादाम्बुजसेवया सुकृतिनो गच्छन्ति सायुज्यतां
तस्य श्रीपरमेश्वरी त्रिनयनब्रह्मादिसौम्यात्मनः।
संसाराम्बुधिमज्जने पटुतनून् देवेन्द्रमुख्यान् सुरान्
मातस्त्वत्पदसेवने हि विमुखान् को मन्दधीः सेवते॥
५॥

Just by worshipping your lotus feet a meritorious being attains unison with you and his grandeur is comparable to that of Brahma Vishnu and Shiva .

Who else but a dunce would turn against you and adore these demi gods like Indra etc. who are only experts in drowning in this deep ocean of sansara

Out of the six variety's of emancipation सायुज्यं is being one with the deity and retaining no trace of one's individual existence.

One has to be highly meritorious to attain this since a complete annihilation of one's individual existence doesn't dawn without highly conducive karmas . The entire sequence of karma and their fruition depends on the identification or let us say misidentification with one's empirical nature . This on the other hand depends solely on the munificence of the mother Tara since the jargon of karma and their fruition is too complicated to be resolved by an individual not to speak of setting it right!

There fore ,the meritorious beings earn merits by docility and servitude to the universal mother's feet . Both are interdependent devotion leads to Kushal's or punya as they are called in Buddhism ,पुण्ययामनुमोदनाम् enhances faith and devotion which in turn leads to sayujya Mukti I.e. attaining unison with the supreme goddess. A soul who has been assimilated into the essential nature of Tara inherits all her grandeur and affluence . The grace of one such aspirant becomes comparable to that of the trinity of gods with their consorts.

There is very popular verse by Bhaskararaya refring to seeking the benedictions of the supreme mother directly instead of placating the demigods and then following their course

तवदत्तैश्वर्यभाजःपरमशिवकथंकारमन्यानमर्त्यन् याचे देहीति

Even the paramshiva's grandeur has been bestowed by you how can I ask other demigods to grant me favours.

In this psalm the aspirant refuses to seek favours of demigods since they are confined to their meagre relative and transitory godhood which is acquired through Ma Tara's munificence only. They as the hymn has it are experts only in making one sink in the ocean of samsara and do not lead to liberation . So how can a wise man follow their example or be devoted to them.

Hence selfless love and devotion towards Ma Tara can help an aspirant cross the ocean of samsara which is beset with multiple difficulties

and illusions. One has to constantly pray to the divine mother to grant him/her a vision to see beyond what is visible and to hear beyond what is audible.

Since the divine mother grants both bhukti and mukti, the dispassionate enjoyment of what the world has to offer can lead one to the ultimate bliss and liberation from all bondages.

Swami Paranand Tirth



An analysis of the eternity of the elements of semantic relationship in the context of the Triakagama text of Śrīmad Abhinavagupta

Shivananda Behera

By the very mention of the name of Śrīmad Abhinavagupta, two books suddenly appear in the minds of the readers, *Dhvanyālokalocan*, a commentary on the *Dhvanyāloka*, and *Abhinavabhāratī*, a commentary on the *Nāṭyaśāstra*. That great ācārya attained fame as a distinguished ācārya of the Tantrāgama tradition. Beyond that, He is also worshiped as a *Siddha-ācārya* in the *Kāśmir-śaiva-āgama* or in the *Trika-āgama*. He had written about forty works based on the principles of *tantra* and *āgama*, and everywhere he had explained or achieved the doctrine of *śivādvaita* (non-dual saivism) with various proofs. Many of his various works are outdated and only a few are available today. The āchārya, pointing out the distinctiveness of the Triakagama, mentions:

*Vedācchaivaṁ tato vāmaṁ tato dakṣaṁ tataḥ kulam /
tato mataṁ tataścāpi trikaṁ sarvottamaṁ param //*

There is no insult to the Vedas and others to be understood here by this śloka or verse. Rather, the ācārya wrote this verse to show that, among the paths of mokṣa or the path of achieving Śivādvaita, triakagama is more important than Vedas and others. There, in his own Tantrāgama texts, the ācārya discusses the subject of words, which is equivalent to the grammarians. Proofs of perfection or authenticity of Abhinavagupta in his knowledge of grammar is found in the book *Śrīpratyabhijñāvivṛtīmarśinī*:

*Purṇavyākraṇavagāhanaśūciḥ.*²

Also, in the last chapter of Tantrāloka – *pitṛā sa śabdagahane kṛtasampraveśaḥ.*³

He, who has studied the entire grammar from his father and has entered the depth of science of word / grammar. This description cannot be made for any general grammarian. Even more evidence can be found in the word structures used in his works and in the grammatically accepted principles. Now, the concepts related to the elements of semantic relationships are being presented.

The essence which is asserted in the law of grammar as word (śabda), meaning of word (artha) and relationship between words and meanings (sambandha) is here considered as Vācya, Vācaka & Adhyāsa. Indeed, considering that grammar is originated from Lord Shiva, and since all knowledge that comes from the mouth of Lord Shiva is in the form of Āgama, the followers of the Āgama prove that grammar is also Āgama.

Acārya Bhartṛhari, one of the great grammarians also mentions in his own grammatical and philosophical work *Vākyapadīyam* as Āgama: “*praṇīto guruṇāsmākam ayam āgamasamgrahaḥ.*”⁴

Just as grammarians assert the eternity of a word by the vartika sutra

*siddheśabdārthasambandhe,*⁵

by asserting the eternity of words, their meanings and their relationship, here the doctrine of non-dual-word, nothing is separated from word, (śabdabrahmādvaitavāda) works. Similarly, in the Āgamas and Tantras it is said that nothing is separated from Śiva, that's called non-dual shaivism- śivādvaitavāda. As Śiva is the cause of all illusion of the form of the universe, the followers of the Āgamas prove the eternity of all word-vācaka, meaning-vācya, and relationship of word and meaning- adhyāsa.

¹ Parātrimśikā page- 144

² Śrīpratyabhijñāvivṛtīmarśinī, Part -1, page- 2.

³ tantrāloka 37th āhnika

⁴ vākyapadīyam 2/487

⁵ mahābhāṣya paspāśāhnika

The word reflects itself and word's meaning too, or the reflection of words itself is the reflection of meaning. For the knowledge of meaning, knowledge of words does not require a fixed pre-existence. Knowledge of words does not precede knowledge of meanings, but knowledge of words is absolute. At the same time, they become known. If knowledge of words exists only before knowledge of meaning, then relativity would also be attained and word couldn't be known as absolute. Thus, the word is reflector of itself and its own meaning. Therefore, the word is taken to be meaningful - **na hi vācyavācakāgame śabdavimarśanapūrvakamarthavimarśanamit i tatrāpi sāpekṣatādi bhavediti | na hi śabdavimarśanādaparamarthavimarśanam kiñcit śabdasya svaparavimarśanatvāt.**⁶

The two forms of words are known: the descriptive word in the form of sound heard and the inner meaning perceived in the intellect. Grammarians call **sphoṭa**, a word that is captured in the intellect. The user uses the audible sound in the form of a word, targeting the same inner sound in the intellect. These sounds which are made up of words, convey the meaning of the word to the listener's mind. That verbal meaning evokes the corresponding meaning in the intellect of the listener. Indeed, this proves that sound is not only the sounds heard, but also the inner sound in the intellect. Reflection is the nature of sound, which is inter-expressive, and that sound is independent of signs

PratyavamarśaścaAntarābhilāpātmakaśabdana svabhāvaḥ,taccaśabdanaṁsamketanirapekṣam⁷

The basic character of the word is initially a single and undivided inner-sound, that's called **Nāda**.

That nāda is transformed into outer-sound, it is stated in the vivekavyākhyā of ācārya Jayaratha of the Tantrāloka that, this unaffected sound becomes the meaning of the word (varṇa) and varṇa is originated from the nāda-

yo'sauanāhatarūpo nādaḥ varṇotpattikāraṇād varṇaśabdābhidheyo bhavatītyarthaḥ⁸.

In this single nāda, all divided outer words are present undividedly. This means that the sound always remains in the rising state and never sets. Because it is unsettling and remains untouched-

**ekonādātmakaḥvarṇaḥ
sarvavarṇāvibhāgavān |**

so'nantamitarūpatvādanāhata ihoditaḥ ||⁹

(The one sound-based character nāda is divided into all characters. That, being of infinite and immeasurable form, is here described as unaffected.)

This is the root sound, or nāda, is the god in the form of word residing in the chest of the living entities. And no one else is able to pronounce it. It is also described in the same verse that the supreme god, in the form of varṇa, speaks Himself. The description that this is situated in the chest of living beings is also grammatically acceptable. Grammarian also proclaim śabda brahma or śabda vṛśabha as being situated in the chest. The mantra from R̥gveda-

catvāri śṛṅgāḥ trayo asya.....tridhā baddho vṛśabho roravīti¹⁰

There is a śloka in the Tantrāloka also -

**nāsyocārayitā kaścitpratihantā na vidyate |
svayamuccarate deva prāṇīnāmurasi sthitaḥ
||**¹¹

⁶ Īśvarapratyabhijñāvivṛtīvimarśinī Part-3, page- 104

⁷ Īśvarapratyabhijñāvimarśinī, Part-1, page. 303

⁸ tantrāloka 5/131, viveka commentary of Jayaratha

⁹ tantrāloka 6/217

¹⁰ mahābhāṣya paspaśāhnika, catvāri, in description of purpose of why study grammar.

¹¹ Tantrāloka 7/57

(There is no one who can utter it and no one who can prevent it, the word uttered itself by living in chest of living beings.)

When the same word is pronounced by different speakers and in different contexts, in what sense does the denoting word become descriptive?

It is said that the signifier of a word is in its general form. The descriptiveness of a word is proved by the similarity perceived in it, even when pronounced by different speakers and in different types. Linguists express this same principle by the word phoneme, which is common form of words. If the same *ka-* *kāra* (word) is pronounced by ten or more speakers, the same shape as *ka* is perceived in the ten *ka-* *kāra* sounds, even when they are heard differently. This is the general relationship between the speaker and the listener with the inner sound - **śabdaśca ābhāsāntaraiḥ deśakālādirūpairanāmṛṣṭe ekatraiva ābhāsamātre pravartate.**¹²

So, what is the expressive meaning or Vācyārtha? The Vācyārtha is the mental image of an object or substance of its own characteristic form in the external. By the external object, the expressive meaning takes on its specific form, or by the external object like Pot (ghaṭa) the expressive meaning of the intellectual object takes on its form. Where there is no objective existence of the verbal meaning, the imagination alone determines the specific form, for example, the horn of a rabbit (śaśaviṣaṇa), like the son of a barren woman (bandhyāputra). Because of the relationship between the external object and the meaning of the word, the characteristics of the external object are imposed to the meaning of the word in the intellect. The fixed form of this verbal meaning is determined by the mind of the proof or by internal consultation. Again, this fixed form of verbal meaning is suitable for use. For example, the mental image of a pot object, the form of the

meaning of the pot (ghaṭa) word, is determined in the form of fixed characters such as gh-a-t-a (p-o-t). The same can be said by determining the fixed form of the meaning of speech in accordance with the alphabet. Even its indefinite form must be a fixed form: if it is meant by the word i-d-a-rṁ (T-h-i-s), without fixed alphabetical form, nothing can be expressed -

**Nahiarthagatād svabhāvda abhilāpavatt
āmanubhavaśya ācakṣmahe viṣayapakṣe
abhilāpabhāga.....apitu
manaskāramāhātmyāditi ākūtaśeṣaḥ.**¹³

Just as grammarians consider two entities of verbal meaning - the main entity and the formal entity, Ācārya Abhinavagupta has asserted two entities of verbal meaning - the mental entity (Mānasikasattā) and the object entity (vastusattā) in his Tantra and Trika texts. The descriptive word or vācaka is related to the mental entity. It is mental reflection, that is imposed on external objects. The descriptive word, on the other hand, is necessarily associated with the expressive word-

**abhilāpasādhāraṇaśca abhilāpena saha tasya
yaḥ prathate, so'bhilāpasamvalita iti yāvat**¹⁴ .
The descriptive word is expressed or expanded in combination with the imaginative form taken in the mind. Then objects such as pots and other objects that are externally present do have meaning, and those objects are not externally presents also get their meaning, like Sky_flower-
sā ca khapuṣpādikamapi vyāpnoti!¹⁵

In trikāgama, when it comes to determining the meaning of the preceding fixed characters, the term called compilation and research is introduced (*saṁkalanānusandhānākhyam*). The listener perceives the various pieces of sound separately through the sense of hearing, connects the pieces of sound perceived by the sense of

¹² Īśvarapratyabhijñāvimarśinī, Part- 2, page- 75

¹³ Īśvarapratyabhijñāvivṛtivismarśinī, Part-2, page- 224-25

¹⁴ Īśvarapratyabhijñāvivṛtivismarśinī, Part-3, page- 78

¹⁵ Īśvarapratyabhijñāvivṛtivismarśinī, Part-1, page- 259

hearing in different ways with each other by electrical motion. Compilation is the fixed understanding of sound fragments connected by electrical motion with determining their meaning —

sadasadanekavarṇaviṣayam, anuvyavasāyarūpam, pūrvavarṇasaṁskārāntyavarṇānubhavajanyaṁ saṁkalanaññānaṁ saṁkalanam.¹⁶

Grammarians also suggest the same, they described in their vākyasphoṭa theory as - **pūrvapūrvapadānubhajanītasamskārasahakṛta-antyapadaśravaṇadvārā-anekapadāvagāhinīmānasī-vākyapratīti.**

The use of speech is possible only by the imposition of the signifier word on the signified meaning or by vice-versa. That is what is said:

vaktiārtham, svādhyāsenaso'yamityabhisamdhānena¹⁷

This is the imposition of a word to the meaning of speech first perceived in the intellect, and the imposition of the meaning of speech to an external object such as a pot. Sound then makes the external form of a pot and other objects as if they were sound and makes itself as if it was objective-

tena parāmarśāvasare śabdah śabdanarūpatām gato'rthamapi bahiṣprakāśamānaṁ ghaṭa iti tanmayīkurvannātmānaṁ vastumayamiva vastu ca sātmanamayamiva saṁpādayati tathāpi ca bahiṣprakāśabhūmau tayorabhedādeva adhyāsavayahāraḥ, anyathā ātyantike aikye katham tadvyavahāraḥ.¹⁸

Thus, the imposition itself is called adhyasa. That is why the behavior of the world is accomplished by this imposition or relation. There is no unity in reality, and it is perceived by this imposition as

one even in difference. This difference should be understood by the Sanskrit word used here - *iva*. In this way, imposition or Adhyāsa, makes the entire external world seem to be sound.

All the behaviors or uses of the words are possible because of imposition. Just as hearing a descriptive word perceives the underlying meaning in the intellect, so seeing the external object attached to the expressive meaning perceives the underlying denoting word. This is not only in the case in *vaikharī*, but also in the middle one (*madhyamā*), where there is a relationship of imposition between the verbal and the descriptive. And that is in the intellect. When, the *mantras* uttered in the intellect for the sake of Pujā, in the act of abhichāra and other rituals, there may be no such thing in the external sense, if the attribution or imposition is not between inner-word/*madhyamā* and outer-world. Without imposition, the use of a word-based mantra, cannot prevail any external meaning-

madhyamā tāvat..... vācye vācakam, tatrāpi vācyaṁ adhyasyate viśvatra | vācye viśvātmani vācakamapi viśvātmaiva- tadaiva parasparācchādanam lolībhāvātmani nirvahed adhyāsaḥ, na tvanyathā¹⁹

The word appears in the the I-ness or in the self of Lord Śiva. Because of *adhyāsa*, this-ness (*idantā*) of meaning imposed on I-ness (*ahantā*) word. *Ahanta* is supreme form, that cannot be used. *Idantā* is the for that is being used in this visual and verbal world. Because of imposition or *adhyāsa*, it is possible to receive word as this-ness, usable. Otherwise, it would not be possible to use the descriptive I-ness word as this-ness. Intellect is only object of I-ness descriptive word. Therefore, when the meaning of the word is imposed on word, then the word becomes usable. This also demonstrates the importance of *adhyāsa*.

¹⁶ śrī śrī parātrimśikāyām page- 112

¹⁷ Īśvarapratyabhijñānavimarsini, Part-1, page- 303

¹⁸ Īśvarapratyabhijñānavivṛtivismarsini, Part- 2, page- 266

¹⁹ Śrī śrī parātrimśikā pg. 237 | samānameva

varṇanaṁ prāpyate -

īśvarapratyabhijñānavivṛtivismarsinyām, Part-2, page- 260 |

There is no contradiction in the view that grammarians and Āgamas believe that the root of meanings and words is Parā vāk. She is the goddess in the tradition of the Agama, and her expansion is this visible dual world. At the time of destruction, the entire universe is absorbed in that Goddess Parā vāk. All speech, which is distinctive and dual in form of words and meanings, merges in the supreme form of indifference or non-dual word. That is Parā vāk.²⁰ This supreme speech goddess is the form of Shakti, and the powerful Lord Shiva is the Supreme Lord- **śaktayo'sya jagatsarvaṃ śaktimāṃstu maheśvaraḥ**. This universe is composed of the power/ vimarśa of Lord Śiva. There, too, the power of Lord Shiva in the form of light is the source of speech. The power, vimarśa or śakti is not separated from lord Śiva, actually Śiva & sakti are non-dual, both are one. Therefore, the four divisions of speech, namely, parā -paśyantī, madhyamā and vaikharī, remain integrally in the Self of Lord Śiva. The words, meanings and relationship between words and meanings, are not different from the essence of speech. Therefore, this is also proved that the relationships between words and meanings are not different Vimarśa. This also proves that they are not different from Lord Śiva. In this way, like Śiva, the whole of speech, which is the subject of words and meanings, are eternal.

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(Shivananda Behera is a Research Scholar at School of Sanskrit and Indic Studies, JNU, New Delhi)

²⁰ parā saikākṣarā devī yatra līnaṃ carācaram |
tantrāloka 6/218

A brief enquiry into Ishavasya Upanishad



Dr G.L Kaw

Upanishadas are the part of Vedangas or simply Vedic literature which has come down to us during a period of more than one thousand years, probably starting from around 1000 BC.

Vedas are not a single text or a set of texts written or narrated at a particular period of time. Most scholars agree that Vedas are the oldest human literature or religious texts of the world. Vedic texts can be grouped as four sets namely:

1. Samhitas 2. Brahman Granths 3. Aranyakas 4. Upanishadas

Samhitas are four in number Rigveda, Yajurveda, Samveda and Atharvaveda. These texts contain mainly the details of sacrifices, yagyas, their rituals and recitation of mantras as well as incantations and prayers.

Brahman Granths are liturgical texts and not many of them are extant. The most well known of them is Shatpath Brahman. Needless to point out that these texts have nothing to do with Brahman caste.

Aranyakas were written in isolation and calm of forests by seers who did a serious thinking on the subjects like self (Atman) and the creator (Brahmn). Thus an evolution of knowledge and philosophy was started, which brought a change in the thinking, approach and the attitude of the society in regard to religion and rituals.

Upanishadas are the natural consequences of Aranyka texts and are full of philosophy about human

existence, in fact many scholars consider them as the Gangotri of Indic Philosophy. In Deussen's words, these are "...philosophical conceptions unequalled in India or perhaps any where else in the world."

Etymologically, the word Upanishad consists of three components; Upa meaning near, Ni meaning down and Shad meaning to sit. To sit near (Guru) at a lower pedestal (than the Guru). Upanishadas are mainly in conversational form in which the disciple asks the questions and Guru explains the same in detail. Upanishadas are also called Vedanta, conveying the end of Vedas, or goals or conclusions of Vedic texts. Chronologically also Upanishadas are the latest of the Vedic texts to justify the name Vedanta.

Thus we see, while a student, (brahmachari) reads and chants the hymns (richas of Samhitas); a householder (grahastha) attends to the Brahman granthas which speak of his daily duties and sacrificial ceremonies; the hermit- the man of the forests (vanprastha) discusses the Aranyakas and the monk- one who has renounced the worldly attachments (sanyasin) studies the Upanishadas which specialize in philosophical speculation. This is a beautiful journey from ritual to spiritual. Upanishadas are the most read part of the Vedic literature.

There are many Upanishadas, of them the main are ten texts which have been commented upon by Shankaracharya. They are the oldest ones also. Some put the total number of them at 108, while others give a number of 200 or even more. In fact in last few centuries many texts written were suffixed with the term upanishada, to make them more impressive, acceptable and authentic, irrespective of the fact whether the text had any remotely connection with the Vedas or not.

Ishavasya Upanishad is one of the oldest and derives its name from the Opening word of the text—Isha. It belongs to the Vajesenya school of Yajur Veda, of which it is the fortieth or the last chapter. This is also one of the smallest upanishadas, containing only 17/18 mantras. The core purpose of the text seems to emphasise on the essential unity of the God and the world.

As per ancient tradition it starts with an invocation which is equally profound and purposeful to the main theme of the text. It goes as;

*Purnam adah, purnam idam, purnat
purnam udchyate,*

*Purnasya purnam aadaya, purnam eva
avshishyate.*

Om shati, shanti, shanti.

That is absolute, this is absolute, absolute
comes out of the absolute, taking the absolute
from the absolute, the absolute itself remains.

Om peace, peace, peace.

The first mantra of the text sets the tone for the
main subject of the Upanishad.

*Ishavasyam idam sarvam yat kim cha
jagatyam jagat*

*Tena tyaktena bhunjitha, ma gridhah
kasyasvid dhanam. (1).*

Whatever moves in this moving world is pervaded by
Isha, the God, the ruler or master.

Thus, enjoy everything, with a sense of renunciation
and do not covet what belongs to others. It implies that
everything in this world derives its significance from
its relation to the one eternal truth. In other words it
emphasizes the equality of all the creatures, regardless
of their other features. Having said so, the Rishi
declares that you can enjoy everything here, albeit
with a sense of renunciation. A paradoxical sermon!
How to be a renouncer and consumer at the same time.
Herein lies the subtlety of the thought. The seer wants
us to renounce the idea of a personal proprietary
relationship to any and all things. This is the idea of
Tyaga (tyekten), in the mantra. The universe is taken
here as a becoming, and not a thing. It is a series of
changeable happenings. And it is enveloped by ISHA,
the Lord. Therefore best approach for us is to give up
the sense of attachment to things. This is to renounce
the self-will.

Some scholars interpret the mantra as emphasizing
that we should enjoy whatever is allotted to us by God
(tena). And do not ask for more than what is given.

Upnishadas, including this one, have been translated
and commented upon for last few centuries by both the
scholars of east and west. The most famous authentic
and profound commentary is of Shrimad
Shankaracharya of eighth century, which prompted

other Acharyas also to write the commentaries
afterwards. The first well known translation in a
foreign language was done by Dara Shikoh, younger
brother of Aurangzeb, the mughal emperor in Persian
language in 1656/57, titled “Sirr-i-Akbar” the greatest
mystery. He tries to emphasise that Islamic Sufi
philosophy is akin to Vedanta thought. This very
translation reached France via Iran and incited a keen
interest in Indic philosophy in Europe. Afterwards
many western scholars translated as well as
commented upon Upnishadas. But to me, one of the
most interesting and profound commentary on this
first mantra is from Mahatma Gandhi which I shall
quote in full. “The mantra describes God as the
Creator, the Ruler and the Lord. The seer to whom the
mantra or the verse was revealed was not satisfied
with the very frequent statement that God was to be
found everywhere. But he went further and said,’
Since God pervades everything, nothing belongs to
you, not even your own body. God is the undisputed
unchallengeable Master of everything you possess.’ If it
is universal brotherhood--- not only brotherhood of
human beings but of all the living things.---I find it in
this mantra. If it is unshakable in the Lord and
Master—and all the adjectives you think of—I find it
in this mantra. If it is the idea of complete surrender to
God and of the faith that he will supply all that I need,
then again I say I find it in this mantra. Since He
pervades every fibre of my being and all of you, I
derive from it the doctrine of equality of all creatures
on earth and it should satisfy the cravings of all
philosophical communists. This mantra tells me that I
can not hold as mine anything that belongs to God and
that, if my life and that of all who believe in this
mantra has to be a life of perfect dedication, it follows
that it will have to be a life of continual service of
fellow creatures.” Address at Kottayam, Harijan,
1937.

The same Mahatma says somewhere else, ‘If by any
chance all our religious scriptures are destroyed except
this one mantra, I feel we have enough guidance for
leading a pious and purposeful life.’

For the purpose of this article I will write about only a
few of the remaining verses.

*Tad ejati tan naejati tad dure
tad vad antike*

*Tad antarasya sarvasya tad u
sarvasya bahyatah. (5)*

That moves and That move not; That is far and that is near; That is within everything and That is outside all this.

This reads like contradictory statements, but that is not due to the ignorance of the writer, but it shows his struggle to describe the indescribable, because of the limitations of human thought and language. The Absolute is beyond the faculties of thought. Therefore he takes the help of negations, though the Absolute is nota void. It is all that is in time and yet is beyond time.

It is far because it is not attainable by an ignorant, and it is very near to the wise for it is his very self.

*Yasmin sarvani bhutani atma
evabhud vijanatah*

*Tatra ko moha kah shoka
ekatvam anupashyatah. (7).*

The wise, who knows, all beings become one with his own self, then how can he be deluded or why should he be sad, when he has experienced the oneness?

When unity and equality of all beings is realized he becomes liberated from confusion and sorrow which are the products of dualities. When the self of the perceiver becomes all things and all things are perceived in the self, there is no room for care or sorrow. Thus the sense of Ekatvam- oneness liberates him from all worldly maladies.

In the next few mantras there is a discussion about Ignorance and Knowledge; The Manifest and The Unmanifest. This discussion is not quite straight forward, and many commentators have given quite varied interpretations of the same. The beginners or the uninitiated are bound to get confused and lost in the jargon of interpretations. I think that is the reason last four mantras are in the form of prayers for unveiling the truth. The no. 15 mantra is quite confessing, straightforward and pleading at the same time:

*Hiranmayena patrena satyasi apihitam
mukham,*

*Tat tvam pushan apavrenu satyadharmaya
dreshtaye. (15).*

The golden disc is hiding the Truth. May you , Oh Pushan , unveil it , so that I who love the truth may be able to see it.

I can only say, TATHA- ASTU !

(Dr G.L Kaw is a medical practitioner based in Gandhinagar Gujarat with an avid interest in history, philosophy, classical Sanskrit and Persian literature)



The Universal Mother



Rashneek Kher

She the multitude & the universe,
Unuttered sound & the unsung verse;
Rhyme in poesy, the garland glow
In unison we say, Oh Is that so

Galaxies on her turret lay,
The morning sky, the evening and day;
Of her, Only the adepts know
In unison, we say, Oh Is that so

In her cradle, play time & space,
Gentle & Ferocious, is that her gaze;
Event & Horizon, in the singularity show
In unison we say, Oh Is that so

Amorphous, formed, living & dead,
Un-kneaded dough & the baked bread;
Of her is the darkness & the rainbow
In unison we say, Oh Is that so

In one, two, three & thirty-six,
The shining moon & the eclipse;
What else could manifest, in the mantra though
In unison we say, Oh Is that so

She the secret & the keeper,
The seed, the fruit and the reaper;
To her alone is the ebb and flow
In unison we say, Oh Is that so

In waking, dreaming & in sleep,
Conscious her being, could I keep
Resplendent like the first snow
In unison we say, Oh is that so

(Rashneek Kher is a Kashmiri poet and a literary critic living in exile in Faridabad)

Pratyabhijna made easy 15th and 16th Aphorism

Sutra: Bal labhe vishvam atamsat karoti

Translation: Having attained the spiritual power (in a manner described in the commentary on preceding sutra) the aspirant assimilates the universe

Exposition:

The power of consciousness or chiti by acquiring balam uplifts herself to her essential nature. Before this she remains submerged in grosser manifestation like the veils of body, prana etc.

This is vindicated by Vasugupta in Spanda Karika

“Having seized the power or Balam of the one whose prowess is omniscience all “mantra” are authenticated and decreed as if they were the limbs being manipulated by a person”

Bala or the spiritual power dawns by resorting to the unconditioned essential nature. This balam leads to a spontaneous assimilating of the universe comprising elements from Prithvi upto Sadashiva.

This has been mentioned by the grandmaster Kshemraj in his “Krama sutra”

“The power of consciousness devours the noose of sense perceptions (which limits the awareness)”

This process of assimilating the universal phenomena is not repeated time and again as what good it would have been if it were a transitory process? Owing to the submerging of consciousness in body prana etc and then rising to its pure untainted state one might as well assume that this attaining of bala or assimilation of the universal phenomena happens time and again. Actually the transitory submerging and surfacing from is transitory only from a relative standpoint. The chiti as such illuminates this submerging and surfacing independently. Chiti is ever self evident otherwise even the body etc. won't appear. Therefore the practice is undertaken merely to eliminate the notion of identification with body as the experient.

No practice is needed to attain the essential nature or

chiti who is the ultimate experiencer. This is the view of the author of Pratyabhijna.

Questions

Balam means

- 1 power of miracles
- 2 stamina of the body
- 3 inherent power of consciousness
- 4 none of the above

Vishvam refers to

- 1 The world
- 2 36 elements
- 3 34 elements
- 4 Entire existence

The assimilation or atmasat is the experience of oneness

1. True
2. False
3. Can't say
- 4.

Describe in five sentences why the attainment of Bala and assimilating the universe is not a repeated phenomena

Sutra: Chidanand labhe dehadishu
Chaityamaneshvapi Chidaikyatma Pratipatti
dardhyam Jivanmuktih

Translation: After the bliss of consciousness has been achieved –one attains jeevanmukti “emancipation even as alive” by the firmness of commitment and feeling that even the insentient entities like the body etc. are also conscious from an absolute perspective, since the whole as such is all pervasive consciousness.

Exposition:

The attainment of Chidanand- Chidanand or the bliss of consciousness dawns upon an aspirant when there is complete identification with all the tattvas during meditative contemplation. When an aspirant sees or

feels the entire universe within himself then even during 'vyutthana' ie. (rising up from the condition of contemplation to everyday normal experience) while experiencing the body, prana (objectivity) there is an underlined firmness and belief in the consciousness of identity with Cit. This consciousness is regularly strengthened with constant contemplation and following various means (upayas- will be discussed in detail in Sutra 18) and which will ultimately lead to Jivanmukti ie. Liberation while still alive.

Spanda Shastra also proclaims

"He who knows thus (i.e the universe is identical with the self) and regards the whole world as a divine play, being ever united with the universal consciousness is without doubt liberated even while alive"

Questions

1. Jeevanmukti is emancipation through knowledge

- a) True
- b) False
- c) Can't Say

2. Body etc. are innately sentient so one has to just maintain it

- a. True
- b. False
- c. Can't Say

3. The body etc. are insentient despite that once the firmness of identification with body etc. has dawned even body etc. are experienced as sentient since nothing insentient remains

- a. True
- b. False
- c. Can't Say

4. For an emancipated soul all worldly undertakings are like casual sporting.

- a. True
- b. False
- c. Can't Say





Notes of Resolution

Ambika Talwar

One never sees the same river twice..

Isn't that in a way really nice?

Away from ripples, one sees better

Ultimately, what does it matter?

Our good emerges from actions not taken

It's god's way to say we are not forsaken.

Friendships are nice and work may be sweet

It's wise to beat a graceful retreat.

Always be joyful, smiling, and purposeful

Allow space to expand -- enjoy the lull

Something greater opens and comes our way

This is now what the spirit has to say.



Gratitude Stirs
~ Ambika Talwar

Grace surprises us with her
responsibility to amaze and
adore our every move, be it
tenacious or mild. And loves our
inspirations to make indigo moons in
tune with our core – so so
ubiquitous. Everywhere we see ourselves!

Deny we cannot our beautiful
existence. Grateful, we are resolved. Now stand

complete in new shiny walking shoes.

Our core resplendent with

man from source to
earth, and so we
smile strong

in this
new body.

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(Ambika Talwar is an India-born author, poet, wellness consultant, artist, and educator whose vision is to realize her sacred destiny and invite others to brilliance. She has authored *4 Stars and 25 Roses* (poems for her father) and *My Greece: Mirrors & Metamorphoses* about her travels through Greece in 2002.)



YOGTANTRAGAMA
ISSN NO: 2454-888X



YTA Yoga Tantra and Agama(Inc)

Published by

Paranand Swami

F-1602, The Resorts

BPTP Greater Faridabad

Haryana .India .121002.

Email: swamiparanand@gmail.com

